

Absolutely — **quite** is an excellent target because it looks simple, but its meaning changes depending on **what kind of adjective/adverb follows it**, the variety of English, and several fixed constructions.

Word family: **quite**

Base word: quite

Part of speech / function: adverb (副詞) / degree modifier (程度修飾語)

Quite has essentially **no useful derivational family**. Its richness comes from its degree meanings and fixed grammatical constructions.

Your sentence:

> “He was **quite tall and thin**, and he always looked neat and well-organised.”

Meaning in your passage: **quite + adjective = fairly / rather** — 頗；相當；挺

Here:

> **quite tall and thin**

means:

> **noticeably / fairly tall and thin, but not necessarily extremely so**

繁體中文：

表示某種性質達到相當明顯的程度，但通常未強到「非常 / 極度」

Natural translation:

> “He was quite tall and thin.”

「他身形**頗高，也偏瘦 / 相當高瘦**。」

So here:

> **quite = 頗；相當；挺**

This is especially natural with **gradable adjectives** such as:

* tall

* thin

* difficult

* interesting

* expensive

1. **quite + gradable adjective/adverb (可分程度) — 頗；相當；挺**

This is your exact source use.

Practice 1 — Original

> “He was **quite tall and thin**.”

「他身形**頗高，也偏瘦**。」

Practice 2

> “The exam was **quite difficult**.”

「那場考試**頗難 / 相當困難**。」

Practice 3

> “She explained the idea **quite clearly**.”

「她把那個概念解釋得**相當清楚**。」

quite + gradable adjective/adverb = 某種程度相當明顯，但通常不表示最高或極端程度

2. **quite + non-gradable/extreme adjective (不可分 / 極端狀態) — 完全；絕對**

This is the biggest semantic trap.

With adjectives that naturally describe an absolute or near-absolute state, **quite** can mean:

> **completely / absolutely**

Practice 4

> “You are **quite right**.”

「你**完全正確**。」

Practice 5

> “The two situations are **quite different**.”

「兩種情況**完全不同** / **相當不同**。」

quite = 強調某個狀態完全成立，而不只是「有點」成立

Common examples:

* quite right = 完全正確

* quite wrong = 完全錯誤

* quite certain = 完全肯定

* quite impossible = 完全不可能

* quite clear = 十分 / 完全清楚

Context matters because some adjectives can be interpreted as gradable.

Critical distinction: **quite** = fairly vs completely

Compare:

Gradable adjective

> “The lesson was **quite interesting**.”

usually:

「那堂課**頗有趣**。」

Absolute/extreme adjective

> “The answer was **quite wrong**.”

often:

「答案**完全錯了**。」

So **quite** does **not** have one fixed Chinese translation.

Its strength depends heavily on the adjective.

3. **quite a/an + adjective + singular noun** (程度相當高) — 頗.....的一個；相當.....的

A very common construction.

Practice 6

> “He was **quite a good teacher**.”

「他是一位**相當不錯的老師**。」

Practice 7

> “That was **quite an interesting lesson**.”

「那是一堂**相當有趣的課**。」

quite a/an + adjective + noun = 強調某人 / 某物在該特質上達到相當明顯的程度

Word order is important:

> **quite a good teacher** ✓

not:

> **a quite good teacher**

> possible in limited contexts, but much less natural for this meaning.

4. **quite a + noun** (令人印象深刻 / 程度突出) — 真是個..... ; 相當了不起的.....

Even without an adjective, **quite a** can emphasize that something is remarkable or notable.

Practice 8

> “That was **quite a lesson**.”

「那真是**很不一般的一堂課 / 令人印象深刻的一課**。」

Practice 9

> “He became **quite a teacher** over the years.”

「多年來，他成了一位**相當出色 / 很有一套的老師**。」

quite a + noun = 強調某人 / 事物非常符合或突出地代表該類別，常帶驚訝、欣賞或強調語氣

5. **not quite = not completely / almost but not fully — 不完全；還差一點；差不多但未到**

A major construction.

Practice 10

> “I **don't quite understand** the question.”

「我**還不完全明白**這條問題。」

Practice 11

> “The answer is **not quite correct**.”

「這個答案**不完全正確 / 還差一點**。」

not quite = 某件事接近成立，但仍未完全達到所需程度

This often means:

> **almost, but not entirely**

6. **not quite + adjective/state (委婉否定) — 不太；未完全**

It can also soften criticism.

Practice 12

> “The explanation was **not quite clear**.”

「這個解釋**不太清楚 / 未完全清楚**。」

Practice 13

> “That is **not quite what I meant**.”

「那**不完全是我的意思**。」

not quite = 用較委婉的方式指出某事未完全正確、準確或達標

This is very useful in polite English.

7. **quite a few + plural noun — 相當多；不少**

This is a classic learner trap because:

> **few = 很少**

but:

> **quite a few = 相當多**

Practice 14

> “**Quite a few students** remembered the teacher.”

「**相當多學生 / 不少學生**仍然記得那位老師。」

Practice 15

> “I made **quite a few mistakes** in the first draft.”

「我的初稿犯了**不少錯誤**。」

quite a few = 數量相當多，而不是「很少」

This is extremely useful MCQ material.

8. **quite a bit / quite a lot (數量 / 程度) — 相當多；頗多**

Practice 16

> “I learned **quite a lot** from him.”

「我從他身上學到了**相當多東西**。」

Practice 17

> “The school has changed **quite a bit**.”

「這間學校已經改變了**不少 / 相當多**。」

quite a bit / quite a lot = 數量或變化程度相當大

Very common in conversation.

9. **quite a bit of / quite a lot of + noun** — 相當多的.....

Practice 18

> “The project required **quite a lot of work**.”

「這個項目需要**相當多工作**。」

Practice 19

> “He spent **quite a bit of time** preparing his lessons.”

「他花了**不少時間**準備課堂。」

quite a bit/lot of = 某種事物的數量相當大

10. **quite some + noun** (很可觀 / 很突出) — 相當大的；相當不得了的

A useful emphatic construction.

Practice 20

> “That caused **quite some confusion**.”

「那造成了**相當大的混亂**。」

Practice 21

> “He had **quite some influence** on his students.”

「他對學生有**相當大的影響**。」

quite some + noun = 強調某事的數量、程度或影響相當顯著

This is less neutral than simply:

> some influence.

11. **quite the + noun (非常典型 / 突出) — 真是個..... ; 相當.....**

A common modern informal expression.

Practice 22

> “He was **quite the storyteller**.”

「他真是個**很會說故事的人**。」

Practice 23

> “She has become **quite the expert** on local history.”

「她已經成了**相當厲害的地方歷史專家**。」

quite the + noun = 強調某人 / 某物非常具有該身分或特質，通常帶欣賞、驚訝或輕微幽默語氣

Register: conversational/informal.

12. **quite enough = fully sufficient — 完全足夠 ; 已經夠了**

Practice 24

> “We have **quite enough information** to make a decision.”

「我們已有**完全足夠的資料**作出決定。」

Practice 25

> “That is **quite enough** for today.”

「今天到這裡就**已經完全足夠 / 夠了**。」

quite enough = 所需數量 / 程度已充分達標，沒有必要再增加

Depending on tone:

> “That’s quite enough!”

can mean:

****夠了！不要再繼續！****

13. **quite so (確認同意；較正式 / 英式) — 正是如此；的確**

A useful conversational expression, though somewhat formal or British in flavour.

Practice 26

> “So the real problem was the teaching method?”

> “**Quite so.**”

「所以真正的問題是教學方法？」

「**正是如此。**」

Practice 27

> “You mean students should think, not just memorise?”

> “**Quite so.**”

「你的意思是學生應該思考，而不只是背誦？」

「**正是這樣。**」

quite so = 強烈確認對方剛才的說法完全正確

Register: formal / especially British.

14. **quite apart from + noun/gerund (另且不論 / 除此之外) — 撇開……不說；更何況還有……**

A useful formal fixed expression.

Practice 28

> “**Quite apart from** the exam results, the students became more curious.”

「**撇開考試成績不說**，學生也變得更有好奇心。」

Practice 29

> “Quite apart from being knowledgeable, he was also patient.”

「**撇開他知識豐富這一點不說**，他也很有耐性。」

quite apart from = 即使不考慮某一因素，仍有另一個獨立的重要理由 / 事實

Register: somewhat formal.

15. **quite** another / quite a different + noun — 完全另一回事；相當不同的**quite**

Practice 30

> “Memorising facts and understanding history are **quite different things**.”

「背資料和理解歷史是**很不一樣的兩回事**。」

Practice 31

> “Teaching well is **quite another matter**.”

「教得好是**完全另一回事**。」

quite another / quite different = 強調兩者之間有明顯甚至根本性的差別**quite**

Here **quite** is closer to:

> completely / distinctly.

Important distinction: **quite** vs **very**

This is essential.

very

normally means a clearly high degree:

> “He was **very tall**.”

「他非常高。」

quite

with gradable adjectives often means:

> fairly / rather

> “He was **quite tall**.”

「他頗高 / 相當高。」

So in your source:

> **quite tall**

is normally weaker than:

> **very tall**

However, **quite** can become stronger with absolute adjectives:

> “quite impossible”

= 完全不可能

So **quite** ≠ always weaker than **very**.

Important distinction: **quite** vs **fairly**

With gradable adjectives:

fairly

often moderate:

> fairly difficult

「頗難」

quite

can range from moderate to fairly strong depending on context and variety.

> quite difficult

「頗難 / 相當難」

In British English especially, the exact strength of **quite** is highly context-sensitive.

Important distinction: **quite** vs **rather**

These often overlap.

****rather****

frequently suggests:

- * more than expected;
- * sometimes an undesirable degree.

> “The exam was rather difficult.”

「考試頗難 / 比預期難。」

****quite****

is often more neutral:

> “The exam was quite difficult.”

「考試相當難。」

But both are flexible.

Important distinction: ****quite vs completely****

****quite****

can mean completely with certain adjectives:

- > quite certain
- > quite impossible

****completely****

explicitly means totally.

> completely impossible

So ****completely**** is semantically clearer and less dependent on adjective type.

Important distinction: ****quite tall vs quite right****

This is the key contrast.

quite tall

tallness is gradable.

So:

> **quite = fairly/rather**

quite right

rightness is often treated as an absolute judgment.

So:

> **quite = completely**

Therefore:

> **quite tall** ≠ “completely tall”

> **quite right** ≠ merely “fairly right”

Important distinction: **quite good**

This phrase can be tricky.

In many British contexts:

> “It was **quite good**.”

often means:

頗好 / 相當不錯

and may sound **less enthusiastic** than:

> “It was very good.”

But intonation and context can make **quite good** fairly positive.

So learners should not assign a rigid numerical strength to **quite**.

Important distinction: **quite a few** vs **few**

This is one of the most important traps.

few students

= 很少學生

quite a few students

= 相當多學生

So:

> **quite a few** reverses the practical implication of **few**.

Important distinction: **quite a few** vs **a few**

a few

= some, a small number

> “A few students stayed.”

「有幾個學生留下。」

quite a few

= a fairly large number

> “Quite a few students stayed.”

「有**不少學生**留下。」

Important distinction: **quite a lot** vs **very**

quite a lot

usually concerns:

* quantity;
* extent of change/action.

> “I learned quite a lot.”

「我學到了相當多。」

very

cannot normally replace it:

> “I learned very.”* ❌

Important distinction: **not quite vs almost**

They are closely related but point in different directions.

almost

approaches the target positively:

> “The answer is almost correct.”

「答案幾乎正確。」

not quite

emphasizes that it still falls short:

> “The answer is not quite correct.”

「答案還不完全正確。」

Both describe a near-target state, but the perspective differs.

Important distinction: **quite a teacher vs a good teacher**

a good teacher

directly evaluates teaching quality.

quite a teacher

more expressive:

the person is notably/impressively teacher-like or accomplished.

> “He became quite a teacher.”

can convey admiration or surprise.

British / American usage note

Quite is common in both varieties, but its degree interpretation can differ subtly.

In British English especially:

> **quite + gradable adjective**

often means:

> **fairly / rather**

while:

> **quite + absolute adjective**

often means:

> **completely**

American English can also use **quite** quite strongly:

> “That was quite impressive.”

= 那相當令人印象深刻。

So context and adjective type matter more than trying to memorize one fixed translation.

Family-extension sweep

Quite has no meaningful derivational family, so the useful modern network is construction-based:

* **quite + gradable adjective/adverb** = 頗 / 相當

* **quite + absolute adjective** = 完全 / 絕對
 * **quite a/an + adjective + noun** = 相當.....的一個
 * **quite a + noun** = 真是個 / 相當不得了的.....
 * **not quite** = 不完全 / 還差一點
 * **quite a few** = 相當多 / 不少
 * **quite a bit / quite a lot** = 相當多
 * **quite a bit/lot of** = 相當多的.....
 * **quite some + noun** = 相當可觀的.....
 * **quite the + noun** = 真是個 / 相當.....
 * **quite enough** = 完全足夠
 * **quite so** = 正是如此
 * **quite apart from** = 撇開.....不說 / 除此之外
 * **quite another / quite different** = 完全另一回事 / 相當不同

This is a relatively compact family, and I would stop there rather than inflate it with rare literary constructions.

Master comparison

Form / function	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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* **quite + gradable adjective/adverb**	表示某種性質 / 方式達到相當明顯但通常非極端的程度； 頗 / 相當
* **quite + absolute/extreme adjective**	強調某個狀態完全成立；完全 / 絕對
* **quite a/an + adjective + noun**	強調某人 / 物在某特質上達到相當明顯的程度
* **quite a + noun**	強調某人 / 物非常突出或令人印象深刻地屬於該類別
* **not quite**	接近某個狀態 / 標準但尚未完全達到
* **quite a few**	可數事物的數量相當多，而不是很少
* **quite a bit / lot**	數量、變化或程度相當大
* **quite some + noun**	強調某事物的數量、影響或程度相當顯著
* **quite the + noun**	強調某人 / 物非常具有該身分或特質
* **quite enough**	所需數量或程度已完全足夠
* **quite so**	強烈確認對方所說的內容完全正確；正是如此
* **quite apart from**	即使撇開某一因素不考慮，仍有另一獨立理由 / 事實
* **quite another / quite different**	強調兩者之間存在明顯甚至根本差異

For your original sentence

> “He was **quite** tall and thin, and he always looked neat and well-organised.”

The exact meaning is:

quite = 修飾 tall 和 thin，表示這兩個特徵相當明顯，但並不是說他極端地高或瘦

So:

> **quite tall and thin**

= **「頗高而且偏瘦 / 相當高瘦」**

Natural full translation:

> **「他身形頗高也偏瘦，而且總是看起來很整齊、很有條理。」**

The key contrast to remember is:

> **quite tall** → 頗高 / 相當高

> **very tall** → 非常高

> **quite right** → 完全正確

> **not quite right** → 不完全正確 / 還差一點

That adjective-dependent shift is the central learning point of **quite**.